

The Model Tenth

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In the psychological thriller *Get Out*, writer-director Jordan Peele expresses the deep-seated fears and subtleties of racism against Black people in America. For a majority of the film, the protagonist Chris is the only Black character surrounded by White people when he is brought upstate to visit his girlfriend's family. There is one exception to this predominantly Black and White dynamic of *Get Out*, and that is when an Asian man briefly appears during one of the most tense moments of the film. While the White people auctioning over Chris' body ask him unnerving and oddly pointed questions about his individual body and physicality, the Asian man asks Chris if he thinks being African-American in America has more advantages than disadvantages. This man's question suggests an awareness that, although Asians may be regarded more favorably by the White majority, this comes at the expense of being considered a "forever foreigner."

Peele's inclusion of this single Asian man accomplishes a few things. It broadens the scope of the film to include more than just Black and White America, pointing to a larger epidemic of racism, thus allowing the discussion to include interracial relations among minority. Another explanation is that, in the comparative nature of the Asian man's question, he wonders if the Black experience may be preferable to his own as an Asian American. This would speak to the difficulty of Asians in fitting into an America that tends to see race as an issue exclusive to Black and White. Consequently, this racial binary obscures the role that Asian Americans ought to play navigating racial issues. Oftentimes, Asian Americans perceive themselves as neither the primary instigators of racial inequality nor its main victims.

Moreover, not only does the Asian man contribute to the stereotype of Asians as foreigners, but it also perpetuates the model minority myth. Undoubtedly, some audience members might interpret the Asian character in *Get Out* as suggesting that the Asian experience

is akin to that of White Americans. This interpretation is ironic given the medium of film, a form of art that routinely excludes Asians from their own narratives and consistently lacks Asian representation. The decision to specifically cast just one Asian takes a mimicking stance on the proportionality of racial demographics in America - according to the Pew Research Center, Asian Americans make up 5.8% of the country, while Black Americans stand at 13.3%. Although Asians are outnumbered by Black folks, they can still complicitly take on the role of the oppressor by standing on the side of white supremacy and anti-Blackness (“Asian Americans”).

Peele’s utilization of a singular Asian person in *Get Out* serves as a reminder for all non-Black people to reflect on their contributions to systemic racism. Belonging to one minority group does not automatically exempt one from perpetuating racial inequities. However, his methodology in portraying such an individual trivializes the Asian American experience - the discussion of relations between Asian and African Americans is important, and it deserves more than a throwaway line in a stereotypical broken Asian accent. This shows that even the most intelligent films can fall prey to Asian-American stereotypes. Nonetheless, Peele deserves much credit. Ultimately, the main thing that made the main character desirable was his “eye” or “vision” for good photography, an analogy for the Black filmmaker. When the Asian man asks the main character if there are advantages to being Black, the question insinuates an envy that there is a potential advantage to being Black in America. Black people are gifted with, and hyper aware of, a double sightedness, an understanding of both the Black and White man. Asian Americans, particularly those who have assimilated in White society, definitely also have a unique multi-pronged vision. However, the hyper-visibility and invisibility paradox faced by Asian Americans complicates their double-sightedness, thus *Get Out* helps a broad audience

realize that for all of Asian success, there still remains an envy for the Black eye. This interchange in *Get Out* is a microcosm for the rest of the paper, where the Asian model minority meets the Black intellectual. Through a conversation between Black and Asian thinkers, in conjunction with creative artifacts and literature, the difference in minority assimilation will be explored, concluding with a revaluation of how to achieve minority solidarity.

The African American Experience

Du Boisian Logic

Peele's movie is artwork pieced together originally and meticulously, contributing to the success in showcasing the tangible fears that Black Americans experience as they navigate White-dominated spaces and relationships with supposed allies. To fully appreciate African American art, the critical thought of W.E.B. Du Bois must also be cultivated and engaged with. In *The Souls of Black Folk*, Du Bois spoke of an African American "double consciousness," a "two-ness" of being "an American, a Negro; two warring ideals in one dark body, whose dogged strength alone keeps it from being torn asunder" (11). The experiences and destiny of his own and the general Black American's consciousness is dependent upon the intricately connected relationships and dialogue of minority and majority subjectivities; as two entwined, but systematically separate forms of consciousness. A double consciousness, a two-ness implies a taunting duality in the African American's life. In large part fuelled by historic racism, this duality represents the constant paradoxical tension of being both an integral part of society, while also being excluded from the nation's public culture. Or, in Du Boisian terms, "being an outcast and stranger in my own house" (11). This consciousness, as outlined by Du Bois, is loosely composed of four facets: African American internalization of white America's contempt towards them, the development of an additional perspective or a "gifted second sight" that this two-ness

births, the experience of having fewer civic rights despite retaining the holistic duties of American citizenship, and the unwavering maintenance of unreconciled ideals that clash with norms set by white society (14). For a racial group always presented as the Other, the African American's life becomes an echo of White America's racism. It must be noted that this Black self conception is not derivative of their inherent, atomistic self, but rather a conception resulting from cultural ingratiation and social mediation. Thus, Du Bois argues that in grappling with recognizing the self, a broader notion of cultural recognition is achieved, in which an individual identity is contextualized with the cultural identities of other members of one's community. So then, the traumas endured from racism do not arise exclusively from the majority's overt hostility, but also from a large degree of minority invisibility. African Americans' conception and consciousness of self is constructed through a contorted view of another. That is, through the unrelenting dominance of one group, contingent on their historically established role as "master," to recognize African-Americans wholeheartedly. In constructing an understanding of self through this manner, the role of nuance and subjectivity presents itself in Du Bois' insistence that African-Americans can understand the ideals of freedom in a way that white Americans simply cannot.

In a passage from *Strivings*, Du Bois refers to this as a "second sight...flashes of clairvoyance, some clear idea of what American really is. We who are dark can see America in a way that Americans cannot" (Du Bois, 1971, p.416).

This second sight directly relates with his subsequent construction of the notion of the veil. There is a veil in society, with African Americans behind the veil, and White Americans in front of it. Those behind White America, the powerless groups in society, constantly watch the actions of

dominant society, whereas those in front of it do not see the excluded members. In this sense, the Du Boisian veil may be conceived as a one-way mirror, with the minority seeing the majority through the glass, while the latter fail to see society's marginalized groups, observing only their own reflection of beauty and superiority. This veil and metaphorical one-way mirror forces the powerless to constantly see and account for the powerful in any action they perform. Thus, this sets a basis for the nuances of Du Bois' double consciousness and why second sight is both a gift and a curse.

It is because of this power differential and mental struggle in African-American society that another Du Boisian concept arises: the Talented Tenth. At the core of his logic, Du Bois argued that educated African Americans have an innate obligation to sacrifice their personal interests and endeavors in favor of improving the social, economic, and political conditions of their people. Members of this elite ten are compelled to work for the noble cause of racially advancing the remaining nine-tenths, as evidenced through their "willingness to work and make personal sacrifices for solving the problems" of African-Americans (*Talented Tenth*, pg.3). In a time of existing anxiety and unrest, the majority of African Americans were unwilling to make personal sacrifices. Keep a stable job and provide for your family, or join an undeveloped movement, facing potential loss of financial stability and familial safety? To abandon all sense of security in pursuit of racial justice underscores the courage of the Talented Tenth, as they understood that the immediate need of intellectual leadership surpassed all other needs. Despite Du Bois' intention of conveying a humanist perspective in his proposal of the Talented Tenth, his initial articulation of this educated group faced criticism for his perceived elitism. One of the most notable and outspoken critics, Booker T. Washington, accused Du Bois' Talented Tenth of plaguing their minds with mere theory and ideas.

“In cramming their head full of book knowledge, they have lost contact with the real world and real people...members of the educated class [are] pursuing their own goals rather than the goals of the masses” (*Rutledge M. Dennis*, p.392).

Admittedly, it is unsurprising that Du Bois’ first version of his suggested Talented Tenth was misconstrued for possessing sentiments of elitism. However, in 1948, Du Bois publicly amended his original ideas about the Talented Tenth. He encouraged the expansion of the group he was pushing for, but advocated for a broader membership demographic that valued individual traits over wealth or prestigious education:

“This new membership must not simply be successful in the American sense of being rich; they must not all be physicians and lawyers. The [people]...admitted must be those who...do not think that private profit is the measure of public welfare” (Du Bois).

As a basis, Du Bois sought after unselfish men who possessed adequate character traits - not just men with accolade after accolade. Despite unintentionally possessing a certain exclusiveness and snobbery, Du Bois’ original conceptualization was genuine in attempting to promote self sacrifice. According to 1986 U.S. Census data, “it was not until 1984 that at least ten percent of Black Americans over the age of 25 completed at least four years of college” (“Statistical Abstract”). If Du Bois’ radical Talented Tenth was propelled into action three generations earlier when it was proposed, would it have taken two more generations for the eruption of the modern civil rights movement? The Voting Rights Act? Would these have even been necessary? Du Bois’ vision had real potential to save the Negro race, had there not been undertones of elitism

(*Talented Tenth*). Therefore, there must be a better method for catalyzing nonblack recognition of Black people. A full and scrutable articulation of a revamped Talented Tenth, described in such a manner to prevent possible misperceptions of his concept.

Black Artwork

In *Dusk of Dawn*, a somewhat autobiographical book summarizing the arc of his social and political views, up until his seventies, Du Bois proclaims that from his childhood, he has been “impressed with the beauty of Negro skin-color and astonished at the blindness of whites who cannot see it” (698). As the founding editor of *The Crisis* magazine, Du Bois began producing and utilizing existing art to convey the Negro beauty. Political cartoons, drawings, photographs, and prints were sourced and scattered throughout pages of *The Crisis*, all of which were created exclusively by black artists. The art was dignified, self-respecting, and exuding race-pride. Perhaps then, whereas education is more tangibly a transformative process for one individual, impact visuals help define a collective memory for all black and nonblack readership. Du Bois also asserted that African-Americans made their greatest contributions to American culture in art and labor, concluding that the only true American art was Negroid.

One large contributor to American art through Black beauty is Matthew Angelo Harrison, a featured artist in Stanford Cantor Art Museum’s *Day Job* exhibit, who voices a similar sentiment. The exhibition’s premise is an examination of the overlooked impact of day jobs on visual arts. Success for artists is usually measured by their ability to quit a day job and practice artistry full time, but often, day jobs can spur creative growth by providing artists with new materials and mediums. For sculptor Harrison, he shares that his artistic focus is on “the idea of the archive, with longevity and perpetuity” in relation to the preservation of African-American history (Salon 94). He is known for his clear block encapsulations in resin of African artifacts

that scrutinize and preserve the ineradicable effects of racism and colonization. Harrison has also begun encasing artifacts of the African-American working class, speaking to labor inequality and the politics of mass production.



Figure 1: *The Invisible Hand*, 2023



Figure 2: *Operimentum*, 2023

In Figure 1, Harrison uses Adam Smith's "invisible hand" and extends the metaphor to the reification of African Americans. The invisible hand is not some economic phenomenon that equalizes the free market, but the labored hands of African Americans who produce for a society they are alienated from. Whereas many artists choose efficiency and outsource the fabrication of sculptures, Harrison has always insisted on mastering the techniques himself in order to slow down the management of the process. Ironically, his extremely hands-on approach results in pristine sculptures where evidence of a human's labor is not evident. In some ways, *The Invisible Hand* is reminiscent of a popular Surrealist motif - a severed hand symbolizing fetishization that can generate both pleasure and pain. In this case, the hand, isolated from the rest of the body,

emphasizes the pain generated from the toiled hands of the African American, and their attempted detachment from such affliction. Similarly, Harrison directly addresses his, and many others', past day job in Figure 2 - that of industrial work. By encapsulating the hard hat in resin, he pays homage to his family's history as laborers in the automobile industry in a way that onlookers cannot put distance between themselves and an unjust history. Using Ramell Ross' words, a prolific Black visual artist, filmmaker, and writer, Harrison is "putting time into the concept of Blackness" (Ross, 31:55). Perception is coterminous with memory, and a lot of nonblack artists portray Black people with negative qualities, like laziness or a certain air of casualness. In turn, faulty artwork causes the audience to perceive Black people with similar qualities. As these qualities are committed to memory, Blackness becomes a concept that has become a fictitious paradox. A fiction that has produced a nonfiction, or rather, a faulty narrative that has materialized into the way people really live their lives. Jorge Eduardo Sibaja, the curator of *Day Jobs*, echoes a similar point.

"Matthew's work materializes a suspension of ascribing meaning to something...encasement in resin places the work into a past but also a future. We're thinking about what these objects he's placing into resin will mean in the future, and what will remain legible to notions of Blackness."

In relation to the Talented Tenth, Du Bois would categorize the day job possessing artist as one who remains in the unrealized nine tenths, those who are unable to give up financial security in the face of raising community standards. Instead, Du Bois would be a proponent for memorializing their personal life, like Harrison does in resin, and striving for the noble cause of racial advancement. These counter cultural things that Harrison chooses to preserve create a new, less determinate horizon of possibility for African-Americans, with almost a post-human reading

by virtue of them being encased. The way people photograph, paint, and depict people and concepts is vital to the way they themselves, and external audiences perceive the object of their artwork.

The Asian American Experience

The Model Minority

In contrast to the earlier review on African American literature and artwork, it appears that review on the Asian American experience reflects in a more paradoxical manner. Through construction of the model minority myth and the perpetual foreigner archetype, Asians are simultaneously valorized and ostracized. This contradictory situation leads to an internal struggle with one's Asianness, and also an external projection onto other minority groups.

Primarily, the false pretense of the "model minority" has been constructed to specifically praise Asian Americans for apparent success across academic, economic, and cultural domains, typically in contrast to the perceived achievements of other racial groups (Lee et al.). Oftentimes, the model minority is thought to be complimentary as the promise of being viewed through the lens of a positive stereotype by dominant societal groups offers an incentive for Asian Americans to produce top quality work and continue their established cultural legacy. In an 1879 Congressional hearing on immigration from China, there was testimony that Chinese immigrants were "far superior...physiologically and mentally" to Black Americans and possessed "a great deal more brain power" (Harpalani). This construction of Asians as a paragon of exemplary achievement has permeated a vast majority of society's expectations. Fast forward today, in the midst of the Students for Fair Admissions (SFFA) vs. Harvard Supreme Court case, the model minority myth is again emergent as the root of controversy between different minority groups. In

the SFFA's complaint against Harvard, they reference an anecdote from Kai Chan, a first-generation Chinese Princeton doctoral student.

“Is it fair in the name of (skin-deep) diversity to hold back qualified students from admission to the Ivies because of their race? After all, it is a fact that Asians need higher academic achievements than their peers to get admitted to the same school.... I am the son of poor, non-English speaking parents, neither of whom attended high school. They never read to me as a child. They never attended my graduations. I went to some terrible high schools. I worked practically full-time while attending high school and college. But I've never gotten the benefit of the doubt anytime in my life. If anything, I've had to be better than my peers” (COMPLAINT).

Author Julia Lee explores the personal experiences of the model minority in her provocative memoir, *Biting the Hand*. The book details how she pieced together her identity as a Korean American woman in a country that operates under a racial hierarchy. In the book's second part, “Shame,” Lee also presents her undergraduate time at Princeton, where she was blindly indoctrinated into an exclusive culture “built upon whiteness and in service of whiteness” (Lee). Under the influence of the learned pre-professional dreams she *should* be chasing, Lee had a miserably brief stint in consulting, before switching to a doctoral program in English at Harvard. Both times, she floundered and left feeling more disillusioned.

“I'd assumed that a community of people devoted to literature would be kinder and more humane,” than the corporate world she had escaped. “But as I soon found out, academia is no different from other systems of power” (Lee).

Through decades of seeking approval from White teachers and peers, contorting her body to fit into the constraints of the hardworking model minority, she suffered devastating costs and to her self-esteem and mental health. In addition to the hurt suffered by Asian Americans, the model minority also hurts other minority groups. Du Bois makes this point in *Dusk of Dawn*:

“The democracy which the white world seeks to defend does not exist. It has been splendidly conceived and discussed, but not realized.” Instead, the white world insists on “group and racial exclusiveness,” creating a wave of propaganda where racism is not mutually exclusive with democratic/Christian morality (296).

The model minority is used by the White world to construct their desired circle of exclusivity. The myth indicates that Asian Americans, a once inferior people, have become emergent through strategically playing within the rules of the American system. The thought process is as follows: if Asian American immigrants are doing well, other minority groups just need to work harder. In doing so, they too would succeed. Ultimately, the model minority also serves as another tool to perpetuate anti-Blackness.

Perpetual Foreigner Archetype

Indeed, Asians are exalted and praised for having achieved a semblance of parity with their White counterparts, but the model minority concept myth nonetheless maintains the idea that Asian Americans are perpetual foreigners. The model minority framework implicitly assumes that Asians were once inferior and by following a specific subset of values, expectations, and cultural norms, they have achieved enormous economic and academic success. This form of categorization has differentiated Asians as an outgroup that is inherently different from other races, and thus, disallow Asians from ever feeling welcomed into American culture.

The perpetual foreigner experience follows a long history of Asian Americans being excluded and treated as outsiders to American society and culture. From the incarceration of Japanese Americans after World War II, to Chinese and Japanese immigrants being dubbed the “Yellow Peril” in early nineteenth to twentieth centuries, Asian Americans have been perceived as an alien race that is simply incapable of assimilating to American culture. Recent research shows that about one-third of Asian Americans have had a) people act as if they do not speak English, b) say that they should go back to their home country, or c) people criticize them for speaking a non-English language in public (“Asian Americans”). Members of ethnic minorities will always be seen as the Other in the White Anglo-Saxon dominant society of the United States, and will never be seen as wholly American. The constructed foreigner image also has roots in the fact that Asian Americans usually have a strong preference for maintaining their cultural practices. By living according to Asian customs and their unique foods, values, and accents, they retain features identifiable to be markedly different from mainstream dominant society’s ways. Consequently, the Asian American is often seen as illegible, invisible, and unassimilable. A terrifying result of this is that, when positioned as a distinct minority, other people of color become rivals rather than allies. There is so little space in this White world for minority presence, a quota for assimilated minorities, so racial groups internally fight over who gets the spoils. It’s wicked and destructive.

While reading *Biting the Hand*, Black feminist Audre Lorde’s essay “Eye to Eye: Black Women, Hatred, and Anger,” came to mind. Lorde declares that White patriarchal culture has fostered so much internal anger that she has learned how to metabolize hatred and become familiar with anger like “the beat of my heart and the taste of my spit” (Kiguwa 212). Lee similarly traces the source of her unrest to what she calls “the culture of meagerness.” She

recounts that, in contrast to the culture of “abundance” she experienced under Black colleagues, mentors, and friends, the culture of meagerness she grew up in facilitates unnecessary competition for the promise of advancement in society (Lee).

Of course, Lee’s and other Asian Americans’ acceptance among the white community alike should never have been contingent on the rejection of her Asian American peers. Why do so many young minority individuals, thrust into wealthy white environments, feel this way? Lorde and Lee agree that with metabolizing anger comes a deep-seated hatred of self. Growing up in a culture that has no respect for you will teach you methods to degrade and devalue yourself, and subsequently, those around you. If your life is spent chasing in vain pursuit of White society’s parochial expectations, how will you ever construct your own notion of “good,” or of “worth?” These expectations imposed on minorities are unattainable, so the individual learns to despise their repeated shortcomings. They learn to hate themselves. And you learn to hate those around you, because when you learn that there is only enough room for one of you to reach these expectations, you see in others everything you have gradually begun to hate about yourself.

As Lorde eloquently writes, “We do not love ourselves, therefore we cannot love each other” (Kiguwa 219).

Working Against Expectations

The tumultuous paradox of trying to win the support of the white superiority while trying to detach from being a foreigner leads to tortured silences around racial anxiety and inherited trauma. Julia Lee recounts the pivotal moment in which she was able to rework the person she was becoming, through a drastic reordering of her value formation. Her colleague in the African American studies department introduced her to Jamaica Kincaid, who became a mentor. She offered Lee this crucial advice:

“Dare to critique those in authority who expect your subservience for access to privilege. You must bite the hand that feeds you” (Lee).

For someone born into a structured world or power, unknowing that we are not powerful, there comes a devastating moment of realization that we are marginalized. Neither the Black nor the Asian child realizes from looking in the mirror that they are the minority. It is through the structures of power that we accept the inability to speak out, to resist. Early in the book, Lee introduces the Korean concept of 화병 (*hwabyeong*), a colloquial term that translates to “fire illness.” 화병 encompasses very well the physiological symptoms that arise when injustice forces individuals to continuously suppress and swallow their rage. These symptoms go beyond mental anguish, and materialize physically in the form of can include dry mouth, agitation, guilt, and depression. Historically, Lee notes that 화병 has been used in reference to the generations that endured social and economic hardship post-war. However, Lee shows that 화병 still dwells and affects the lives of Asian Americans, so-called model minorities who must maintain calm exteriors while dealing with the pressures of assimilation, achievement, and disrespect. Chances are, the 화병 is inside you too. The strain and restlessness felt in appearing agreeable, when your deepest desire was to scream at those who reduced you to mere racial stereotypes.

In the book's final pages, Lee introduces the idea of “survivance,” a neologism developed by Anishinaabe writer Gerald Vizenor that blends together “survival,” “endurance,” “resistance” and for Lee, “vibrance” (Lee). It beautifully encapsulates the ongoing and evolving project of Asian American identity, an infinite and transcendent process of becoming and transforming. Lee’s memoir then is a bittersweet story of second-generation assimilation, ultimately delivering a powerful apostasy. Instead of acquiescence and the compulsory allegiance to whiteness, Lee

compels like-minded readers to reject these harmful perpetuations of internal and interminority harm. Asian Americans must adopt a seeing beyond ourselves, creating an emergent identity that recognizes our power to perpetuate dominant white notions of success and prosperity. When the discussion of race comes about in the U.S., it is almost always focused on Black and White experiences. Those that don't fit into either group are sidelined. Especially those of Asian descent, who are presumed to be sympathetic to the status quo, by virtue of their characteristic model minority. But this is the Asian American two-ness. This can be utilized to the benefit of Asians. In our position of existential invisibility, we gain power and subversive potential because nobody is looking at us, and we are looking at everything.

Moving to Reconciliation

An important reminder is that the term "Asian American" was coined by the student activists Emma Gee and Yuji Ichioka, deriving inspiration from the Black Power and Black Pride movements, and in solidarity with the Third World Liberation Front. Historically, minority solidarity has not been some enigmatic, inconceivable outcome. The proposal of merging these two together is not creating an "uncritical parallelism between Asian Americans and Black communities" and instead, begins with recognizing the differences in minority racialization ("Black-Asian Solidarity). Based on the discussion in previous sections, this requires acknowledging the model minority's erasure of anti-Asian racism and its illogic in dismissing the necessity of dissent, while acknowledging Black communities' construction through a long legacy of slavery and maltreatment. The paradox of the Asian American experience and the long history of systemic racism against African Americans are what form the notions of racial triangulation. The way Asian Americans, White Americans, and Black Americans interact can be plotted on a graph to form a triangular circuit of sorts.

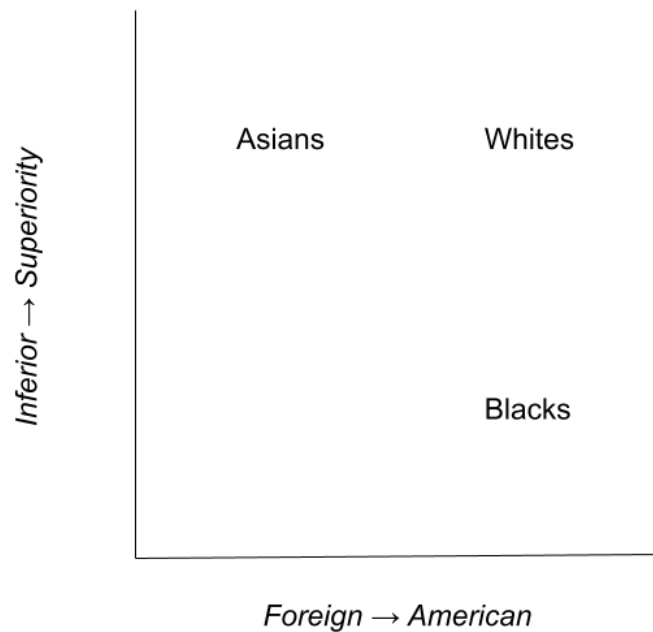


Figure 3: *Racial Triangulation* from Zou and Cheryan (2017)

Through application of White valorization and the model minority myth, the external celebration of Asian Americans' academic and professional achievement insinuates that they have ascended beyond Black Americans in terms of cultural superiority. On the horizontal axis of this visualized graphical representation, we have the extent of ostracism. This can be loosely interpreted as 'foreigner' being at the origin of the axis, while 'American' is at the end of the axis. Due to the perpetual foreigner stereotype - particularly that Asian Americans have more loyalties to their homelands than the United States - Asian Americans fall closer to the 'foreigner' origin side of the graph, while Black Americans fall closer to the 'insider' right side of the graph. Thus, the triangular shape is formed where Asian Americans enjoy more valorization, but Black Americans enjoy less civic ostracism (Lee et al.).

“The only way out of the vicious cycle of violence we continue to find ourselves in is deep, unrelenting and principled inter-community solidarity. As Asians, we must interrogate the

conditions and narratives we find ourselves in and remember in our core that white supremacy is not our savior. We have an opportunity to reclaim our narratives - and our identity - by being loud. Angry. Political. Defiant. And in lock-step with the Black community to keep our communities safe while denouncing the systems that have never protected us” (“Asian Americans and African Americans”).

Clearly, minority solidarity is needed more than ever. Research suggests that solidarity between people of color is triggered when a marginalized ingroup believes they are discriminated against similarly to another outgroup. Therefore, real stories of real people need to be told. They need to be disseminated. They need to be heard. Du Bois’ original project of education and community uplift needs to be revisited. This was not just about securing personal success, but about becoming an educator, a writer, or some sort of creative...all of which are valiant reasons to push for minority success. The value in merging these two minorities lies in achieving understanding that the two marginalized groups have more similarities than previously thought. With this reconciliation, the Talented Tenth can be resurrected with more creative elements, rather than just being an economic uplift.

Du Bois’ vision for the Talented Tenth advocated for the transformative power of education in addressing racial inequalities and uplifting the African American community. His approach highlighted the importance of intellectual rigor and leadership, not necessarily in accordance with the White world’s measures of prestige, but in line with a deep understanding of one’s cultural heritage and broader societal context. On the other hand, the Asian American community has historically cherished the coinage of the model minority, by celebrating students’ academic accolades and pushing towards higher education, often channeled into institutional professions such as medicine, law, and engineering. However, this focus resonates with

Washington's critique of Du Bois' Talented Tenth: at some point the mind becomes ridden with mere theory and book knowledge, lacking a critical engagement with the broader socio-political landscape and an emphasis on liberal arts education. By synthesizing these two approaches to education, we can conceptualize a Model Tenth that integrates the strengths of both traditions to foster a more holistic, inclusive, and socially conscious intellectual body.

Du Bois' advocacy for a liberal education aimed to produce leaders capable of addressing complex social issues. A well-rounded education, inclusive of the humanities, social sciences, and natural sciences, is essential for developing leaders who can adequately and maturely navigate the systemic injustices of their time. Even more than this, there is a necessity for more prolific artists and cross-cultural artists. Through artwork and literature, the most raw, stripped down of emotions can be conveyed. Through mediums that are not just speech or political demonstration, but history trapped in resin, the messages of overcoming racism are made permanent and transcend the follies of time. This is something the Asian community needs to adopt. The Asian American emphasis on academic excellence and entry into prestigious professions demonstrates a strong commitment to educational attainment and socio-economic advancement. Indeed, significant contributions have been made in fields that require high levels of technical expertise and professional discipline. However, this focus undeniably comes at the expense of broader intellectual exploration and social engagement. Similarly, the Black community could adopt methods of Asian mobilization. Although faulty at times, the Asian community has an overwhelming empowering sentiment of, "We can do it." By integrating the strengths of the Asian American community with that of the Black community, we can create an interracial Model Tenth that leaves elitist notions in the past, and moves towards remarkable proficiency in education that *moves*.

Moreover, the Model Tenth would advocate for a more inclusive understanding of leadership and success. It would challenge the narrow definitions of achievement that prioritize certain professions over others and instead celebrate a wide range of contributions to society. Hopefully, the importance of literature and artistic endeavors would be elevated, making it so that *Day Jobs*, as an exhibit, no longer necessitates existence. In practice, this synthesis could be implemented through interdisciplinary educational programs that integrate technical and liberal arts curricula. Universities and colleges could develop initiatives that encourage students to engage with both the sciences and the humanities, promoting a well-rounded intellectual development. Some schools already have existing programs instated, like Stanford's year long Structured Liberal Education course. Granted, these types of courses are usually optional. But why? Interdisciplinary approaches, interminority approaches, interhuman approaches imply an all encompassing *everyone*. This should be mandatory. By drawing on the strengths of both Du Bois' vision for the Talented Tenth and the Asian American emphasis on academic achievement, we can create a new model of intellectual leadership. This Model Tenth would be characterized by a commitment to both excellence and equity, producing leaders who are not only highly skilled but also deeply engaged and passionate with the social and cultural issues of their time. Such leaders would be well-equipped to educate, to support, and to move the aspiring youth.

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	Bob: Share Resources	Bob: Keep Resources
Alice: Share Resources	(5, 5)	(3, 4)
Alice: Keep Resources	(4, 3)	(2, 2)